activists inside Pakistan by supporting Al Qaeda and TTP was a major concern for the country.

Jaish-e-Muhammad (JeM) (the Army of Prophet Muhammad), a Sunni Deobandi jihadi organisation, was launched by Maulana Masood Azhar in February 2000. Its main objective was to support Kashmiris in their struggle against the Indian security forces in Indian-held Kashmir (IHK). It was considered one of the most dangerous India-centric terrorist groups operating from Pakistan.

Maulana Masood Azhar was arrested in IHK in February 1994, but he was released from an Indian jail in exchange for hostages on board an Indian Airline plane, Flight IC 184, which was hijacked by five armed Kashmiri militants and taken to Kandahar (Afghanistan) in December 1999 (Mir, 2009). After a seven-day showdown on a Kandahar airfield, approximately 150 passengers were released when the Indian government finally agreed to release Masood Azhar and two other militants.[1]

In fact, it was Harkat-ul Mujahideen (HuM) that organised this hijacking for the release of Maulana Masood Azhar who was affiliated with it. However, soon after his release, Maulana Masood Azhar developed financial and ideological differences with HuM and split from it.

One of the reasons for this split was the sectarian outlook of Masood Azhar which was not liked by the HuM chief Fazlur Rahaman Khalil.

According to reports, JeM's activists carried out a series of attacks in Indian-held Kashmir between 2000 and 2003. It was blamed for attacking the Parliament of India in 2001 in collusion with Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT). JeM was banned in 2002. It split into two organisations, namely Tehreek-e-Khuddam-ul-Islam (TKI) and Tehreek ul-Furqaan (TF), headed by Masood Azhar and Abdul Jabbar, respectively. The government of Pakistan in November 2003 also proscribed TKI and JUF. As General Musharraf was the President of Pakistan at that time, the JeM militants tried to assassinate Musharraf in December 2003 and again in January 2004. In January 2005, the police traced a network of 19 suspects involved in the 30 July 2004 suicide attack on the Prime Minister of Pakistan Shaukat Aziz in Fateh Jang, Attock, and arrested three brothers belonging to the proscribed JeM and Jamaat ul-Furqan outfits (*Daily Times*, 2004).

After this ban, Maulana Masood Azhar started his operation under the name Al-Rahmat Trust (ART). ART was founded in 2001 and was once managed by Masood Azhar's father, Allah Baksh Shabbir, as an educational